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NUCLEAR PLANNING GROUP

NATO OPERATIONAL CONCEPTS AND DOCTRINE
CURRENTLY GOVERNING EMPLOYMENT OF NUCLEAR WEAPONS
FOR TACTICAL PURPOSES

Report by the Permanent Representatives

I. PURPOSE

This report comments on NATO operational concepts and doctrine currently governing employment of nuclear weapons for tactical purposes.

II. BACKGROUND

2. At their meeting in Mittenwald in May 1971, the NPG Ministers discussed a paper(1) on unresolved problems related to tactical nuclear defence which, among other matters, raised the question of possible improvements in concepts and tactics. In this context, the paper mentioned four factors that might be examined: wider use of lower yield battlefield weapons and their combined use with conventional weapons; the possibility of an early combined use of our conventional and nuclear capabilities as soon as the attack is identified as a major aggression and before our conventional forces have suffered substantial losses, and a constrained but continuing combined use if the aggressor persists in his attack; exploitation of the possible advantage of re-structured and deployed defensive forces against the necessarily more concentrated attacker; and possible reduction of undesirable collateral effects through accurately delivered lower yield and/or fusion weapons and the way of their employment. In a later report containing suggestions for investigating the unresolved problems, the Permanent Representatives expressed the view(2) that the NATO Military Authorities might be requested to provide information on existing concepts and doctrine. The NPG Ministers agreed with this suggestion and invited(3) the NATO Military Authorities to prepare a report outlining operational

This document consists of: 7 pages

- (1) PO/71/226, 10th May, 1971
- (2) NPG/D(71)13, 4th October, 1971, paragraph 7
- (3) NPG/D(71)15, 28th October, 1971, paragraph 18(a)

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concepts and doctrine currently governing the employment of nuclear weapons for tactical purposes. The response by the NATO Military Authorities consists of a basic report prepared by SHAPE(1) and related comments prepared by the Military Committee(2).

III. DISCUSSION

General Comment

3. The SHAPE Report provides information on the operational concepts and doctrine which govern current planning for tactical employment of nuclear weapons within Allied Command Europe (ACE), and which would apply to ACE operations in time of war. The Report identifies the broad political guidance on which the ACE operational concepts and doctrine are based; outlines the general and specific military considerations that are relevant to the development of such concepts and doctrine; and describes these operational concepts and doctrine in considerable detail. In the Report, SHAPE emphasises(3) the dynamic nature of the concepts and doctrine, pointing out that they have evolved over a period of years and that they are kept under continuing review in order to be responsive to political and military developments. They are intended to be detailed enough to provide the necessary direction for effective planning and operations by subordinate commanders without, however, restricting the flexibility of future military operations through rigid contingency planning.

4. The SHAPE Report observes(4) that the concepts and doctrine are consistent with guidance provided by political and military authorities in NATO. Although the Military Committee does not comment specifically on this point, it has on several past occasions reported(5) that military planning by the Major NATO Commanders for the employment of nuclear weapons conforms

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- (1) NPG/D(73)5, 7th June, 1973, hereafter referred to as SHAPE Report
 - (2) NPG/D(73)6, 7th June, 1973, hereafter referred to as MC Comments
 - (3) SHAPE Report, paragraphs 39-40
 - (4) SHAPE Report, paragraphs 7, 40
 - (5) With respect to the Provisional Political Guidelines, see MCM-60-70, 14th September, 1970, paragraph 9(a) of the enclosure (circulated under cover of NPG/D(70)7, 16th September, 1970); for theatre strike forces, see MCM-20-71, 25th March, 1971, paragraph 2 (circulated under cover of NPG/D(71)1, 2nd April, 1971); for ADMs, see MCM-51-71, 29th July, 1971, paragraph 16 (circulated under cover of NPG/D(71)9, 2nd August, 1971)

to the political guidance promulgated by the Defence Planning Committee. Our examination of the SHAPE Report leads us to concur, subject to clarifying comments later in this report, that the current concepts and doctrine are compatible with the specific DPC guidance on nuclear planning(1). We also consider that they are in line with broader DPC political guidance(2) and basic NATO strategy(3). At the same time, we fully recognise the importance of reviewing and updating the concepts and doctrine to take account not only of refinements in guidance provided by higher authority but also of changes in the nature of the threat or in NATO's posture that might be brought about by such factors as modifications of force structure, deployment changes and introduction of improved weaponry.

5. The Military Committee endorses(4) the SACEUR view that the concepts and doctrine outlined in the SHAPE Report provide NATO with the necessary flexibility to respond to potential enemy aggression, and also provide SACEUR and his subordinate commanders with the means to carry out military planning to counter the threat to Allied Command Europe. The other Major NATO Commanders, Supreme Allied Commander Atlantic (SACLANT) and Allied Commander-in-Chief, Channel Command (CINCHAN), have stated that the operational concepts and doctrine currently governing the employment of nuclear weapons for tactical purposes in their respective commands are essentially the same as those set forth in the SHAPE Report and that a suitable basis exists for SACLANT and CINCHAN and their subordinate commanders to carry out military planning to counter the threat to their areas of responsibility. In this context, we note that SACLANT has prepared several documents(5) for the NPG Ministers in the past that have discussed the operational concepts and doctrine pertaining to the employment of nuclear weapons for tactical purposes in the maritime environment in considerable detail.

6. The Military Committee draws attention(6) to one aspect of the possible effects of the use of nuclear weapons in the tactical rôle, namely the objective of weakening the enemy's will to continue aggression, a point that is covered in the SHAPE Report as well(7). We agree with the Military Committee's

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- (1) DPC/D(69)59, 20th November, 1969; DPC/D(69)58(Revised), 10th December, 1970; DPC/D(70)60, 10th December, 1970; DPC/D(70)59(Revised), 21st December, 1972
 - (2) DPC/D(67)23, 11th May, 1967, Annex II as amplified in later documents, such as DPC/D(73)8, 30th May, 1973
 - (3) MC 14/3(Final), 16th January, 1968
 - (4) MC Comments, paragraph 2
 - (5) NPG/Study(71)5, 16th March, 1971; NPG/Study/26, 25th August, 1972
 - (6) MC Comments, paragraph 3
 - (7) SHAPE Report, paragraph 12

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observation that this aspect has significant political implications. Although the main focus of the operational concepts and doctrine outlined in the SHAPE Report is naturally on military applications, these concepts and doctrine also reflect an appreciation of non-military factors that influence the tactical employment of nuclear weapons(1). We feel, therefore, that the operational concepts and doctrine currently governing NATO employment of nuclear weapons for tactical purposes as set forth in the SHAPE Report offer a framework within which Alliance political as well as military objectives can be effectively supported in time of war, as regards both the defence and deterrence aspects.

7. The Military Committee expresses the view(2) that the content and form of the SHAPE Report will assist the Ministers in the investigation of unresolved problems related to tactical nuclear defence. We agree that the Report will be very helpful in this regard, particularly with respect to the examination of the four factors(3) mentioned in connection with possible improvements in concepts and tactics. For example, the SHAPE Report will form an important part of the background information against which the Ministers may discuss the question of early combined use of NATO's conventional and nuclear capabilities(4). Similarly, the outline of operational concepts and doctrine in the SHAPE Report, as supplemented by other information provided by SACLANT(5), will be of value in the investigation of the other factors to which, as noted in an earlier report(6), we expect the current effort in the Follow-On Use Work Programme to make a significant contribution.

Specific Comments

8. Nuclear Weapon Characteristics. With regard to general military considerations that are relevant to the development of operational concepts and doctrine, the SHAPE Report lists(7) a number of ways in which nuclear weapons differ significantly from previous munitions. One of the differences mentioned is the speed and distance capabilities of delivery methods. There are, of course, some systems exclusively dedicated to the delivery of nuclear weapons, such as PERSHING or POSEIDON, that have speed and distance capabilities far greater than delivery methods used

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- (1) See, for example, SHAPE Report, paragraphs 8, 10-13, 20
 - (2) MC Comments, paragraph 3
 - (3) See paragraph 2 above
 - (4) NPG/D(73)12, 9th October, 1973
 - (5) NPG/Study(71)5, NPG/Study/26
 - (6) NPG/D(71)13, paragraph 7
 - (7) SHAPE Report, paragraph 8a

before nuclear weapons were available. On the other hand, many of the improvements in delivery methods made since the introduction of nuclear weapons are applicable in large measure to the delivery of either nuclear or conventional munitions. Advances in aircraft, battlefield missiles and tube artillery come to mind in this regard.

9. Authority to request nuclear weapon release. The SHAPE Report states(1) that SACEUR's decision to request nuclear weapon release could be based, among other things, on requests of governments. It is, of course, clear that governments always have full freedom to suggest to SACEUR that he make a nuclear weapon release request. It is equally clear that SACEUR would not only have the right to take such governmental views into account in reaching his decision but would be expected to do so. On the other hand, mention of this possibility in the SHAPE Report should not be viewed as any infringement on the option of a government to communicate a nuclear weapon release request direct to the Council/DPC and member governments, as provided for in the General Guidelines for Consultation Procedure on the Use of Nuclear Weapons(2). If a government originates such a release request, it would, of course, ensure that the message was sent simultaneously to the Major NATO Commanders in order that their views and assessments could be made available to the Council/DPC and capitals as soon as possible(3).

10. Targets. Reference is made(4) in the SHAPE Report to the broad geographical area in which fixed targets have been identified by SHAPE in connection with the targetting of ACE Theatre Strike Forces and to the possibility that some of these fixed targets might be struck with nuclear weapons for tactical purposes. In the light of existing political guidance which places restraints on making strikes on Soviet strategic nuclear forces and targets within Soviet territory itself under selective release conditions(5), it is evident that not all fixed targets within the broad geographical area mentioned in the SHAPE Report would be suitable tactical targets.

11. Atomic Demolition Munitions. Atomic demolition munitions (ADMs) are specifically mentioned in the SHAPE Report under the discussion of planning flexibility and objectives(6)

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- (1) SHAPE Report, paragraph 23d
 - (2) DPC/D(69)59, 20th November, 1969, paragraph III.3(a)
 - (3) NPG/D(72)2, 17th April, 1972, paragraph 38
 - (4) SHAPE Report, paragraph 16
 - (5) DPC/D(69)58(Revised), 10th December, 1970, paragraphs 26, 27, 96, 116, 122
 - (6) SHAPE Report, paragraph 29

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and indirectly referenced under the discussion of military responses(1). Since ADMs are nuclear devices normally used for demolition purposes or to create obstacles and their employment is, therefore, different from nuclear weapons that are used to attack enemy forces on the battlefield, they are not mentioned specifically in the SHAPE examination of the tactical employment of nuclear weapons in the land battle(2). SHAPE use of the term "land battle targets" in this examination refers primarily to enemy targets that are mobile in nature and thus extremely difficult to define and detect, such as combat and service units, field logistic facilities, command and control facilities, and tactical nuclear delivery systems. We agree that this distinction between ADMs and battlefield nuclear weapons is a valid one, and note that it is reflected in the separate issuance of Special Political Guidelines for the Possible Use of Atomic Demolition Munitions(3). Consequently, the omission of ADMs from the discussion of land battle operations does not imply that they are not covered by the operational concepts and doctrine outlined in the SHAPE Report. On the contrary, we have been advised by SHAPE that these operational concepts and doctrine apply wherever appropriate, to the tactical employment of ADMs.

12. Conditions for Selective Employment. In its discussion of operational doctrine, the SHAPE Report lists(4) a number of situations in which it is visualised that nuclear weapons might be employed for tactical purposes. This listing should be viewed as SACEUR guidance to subordinate military commanders and military planners concerning the possible conditions which could make it necessary for them to propose the release of nuclear weapons for selective employment, and not as an indication that political authorities have made a prior commitment to release weapons whenever such conditions exist. One of the situations mentioned in this part of the SHAPE Report is the need for self-defence against attack by enemy aircraft(5). In amplifying the conditions under which requests might be initiated for the release of nuclear weapons for this purpose, SHAPE has indicated that use of the nuclear capability of the NIKE/HERCULES system in the air defence rôle is envisaged, inter alia, under circumstances such as those outlined in the Provisional Political Guidelines for the Initial Defensive Tactical

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- (1) SHAPE Report, paragraph 26c
 - (2) SHAPE Report, paragraph 31
 - (3) DPC/D(70)60, 10th December, 1970
 - (4) SHAPE Report, paragraph 27
 - (5) SHAPE Report, paragraph 27e.1

Use of Nuclear Weapons by NATO, that is, to prevent a development in the air battle decidedly disadvantageous to NATO; in cases where the continued effectiveness of the NIKE/HERCULES system is threatened; if the aggressor were initiating conventional attacks against the nuclear strike potential of Allied Command Europe; or if NATO resolve to employ nuclear weapons could be demonstrated without causing collateral damage to NATO territory(1).

IV. RECOMMENDATIONS

13. The Ministers may wish to:

- (a) take note of the SHAPE Report(2), the related MC Comments(3) and the clarifying comments in this report; and
- (b) agree that the information provided in these documents, supplemented by information provided earlier(4), is a useful outline of the operational concepts and doctrine currently governing the employment of nuclear weapons for tactical purposes that will be of value in the investigation of unresolved problems related to tactical nuclear defence and in the pursuit of other NPG work.

(Signed) Joseph M.A.H. LUNS

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- (1) DPC/D(69)58(Revised), paragraph 60
 - (2) NPG/D(73)5
 - (3) NPG/D(73)6
 - (4) NPG/Study(71)5; NPG/Study/26